Matt Damon's Ship From 'The Odyssey' Needs Your Help

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The **lifesize** wooden ship in Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey needs some care, and its owners are looking for volunteers to help. The 50-oar Draken Harald Hårfagre is due for routine **maintenance**, and volunteers can apply online, if they can get to Norway by April 2027.

'A project like Draken depends not only on a professional crew and sailing **deckhands**, but also on dedicated volunteers who help support the life of the ship,' its official website says. Volunteering is a hands-on way to help while learning about the ship.

Nolan's movie version of The Odyssey is huge, and much of its scale comes from real effects instead of computer images. The director used full-sized set pieces like a real Trojan Horse. For Odysseus' **galley** ship, Nolan used the Draken. The ship is not exactly right for the time of The Odyssey, but neither is the movie's modern English dialogue, or Matt Damon as Odysseus.

The Draken was ordered in 2010 by Norwegian businessman Sigurd Aase. It is built with overlapping oak planks, based on ship descriptions in Viking poems. At 114 feet long and 26 feet wide, with a single 79-foot-tall **mast**, it is a bigger version of the famous Gokstad ship, built around 890 CE. Its first voyage was in 2012, and in 2016 a crew of 100 rowers recreated the Vikings' crossing from Norway to Newfoundland.

Word Treasure

lifesize -- As big as the real thing.
maintenance -- Care and repairs that keep something working well.
deckhands -- Workers who help sail a ship.
galley -- A long, narrow ship moved by oars.
mast -- The tall pole on a ship that holds the sails.

Background you need

The Draken is a big wooden ship built to look like the ships the Vikings sailed long ago.

It has oars and one tall mast, and a crew rows and sails it across the sea, just as Viking sailors did.

A film director used it in a movie about the hero Odysseus, and now it needs care so it can keep sailing.

Break it down

WHO: The owners of the Draken Harald Hårfagre, director Christopher Nolan, and volunteers.
WHAT: The lifesize wooden ship used in The Odyssey needs routine maintenance, and its owners are asking volunteers to help.
WHERE: In Norway, where the ship is kept.
WHY: The ship needs care to keep sailing, and volunteers help support the life of the ship.

Why it matters

It shows kids that real history and movie magic can meet, and that volunteers can help keep a piece of the past alive.

Test what you remember

1. What is the Draken?

(A) A computer-made movie ship
(B) A Viking museum building
(C) A small toy boat
(D) A lifesize wooden ship used in The Odyssey

2. What does the Draken need now?

(A) A new name
(B) A bigger mast
(C) Routine maintenance
(D) A new movie role

3. How can people help the ship?

(A) Apply online to volunteer
(B) Build a new ship
(C) Write a movie
(D) Buy the ship

4. How long is the Draken?

(A) 114 feet long
(B) 50 feet long
(C) 79 feet long
(D) 26 feet long

5. What did a crew of 100 rowers do in 2016?

(A) Sailed to the moon
(B) Recreated the Vikings' crossing from Norway to Newfoundland
(C) Built a Trojan Horse
(D) Filmed a movie in Norway

6. What is the Draken based on?

(A) A computer game
(B) A pirate story
(C) A modern cruise ship
(D) Ship descriptions in Viking poems

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. The Draken's owners: They say the project depends on dedicated volunteers as well as its professional crew and sailing deckhands.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):